build a tower twice as high but the project was abandoned. The remains of Alauddin Khilji's failed attempt can still be seen nearby.

At the beginning of the fourteenth century, Alauddin Khilji built the new fort of Siri at the site of a military camp northeast of the existing city. The main urban cluster continued to be in the old city but the sultan, who was paranoid about assassins, probably felt safer in the new fort. Unfortunately, within a few years of it being built, Siri fell to a Mongol raid. Alauddin managed to push the invaders back and then took care to strengthen the fortifications. This was a wise move because the Mongols were soon back. This time they captured the main city and pillaged it. However, Alauddin held out in Siri for months till the Mongols decided to go back. There are only a few stretches of walls and other buildings that remain of Siri. Its site is now occupied by the urban village of Shahpur Jat. It is one of the many villages that live on in the urban fabric of modern Delhi and is home to numerous small offices and designer workshops. The rest of Siri is covered by the Asian Games Village that was built to house athletes for the event in 1982.

Water supply has always been a major issue for Delhi. In order to supply the expanding city, Alauddin Khilji built a large reservoir called Hauz Khas. It still exists and is surrounded by a beautiful park, a wonderful place to go for a walk on a sunny winter afternoon. Overlooking the waterbody are the remains of an old Madrassa (Islamic religious school) built by a later sultan and the urban village of Hauz Khas. Since the 1990s, this village has transformed itself into a warren of expensive boutiques and trendy bars. This is ironic because Alauddin was a severe man who strictly controlled the prices of all goods and forbade the consumption and sale of alcohol. [19] Such is the revenge of history.

The Khilji dynasty barely survived a few years after Alauddin and was replaced by another Turkic dynasty, the Tughlaqs. They also decided to build a new city, called Tughlaqabad, and chose a location to the east of the existing city. It is unclear why the first Tughlaq Sultan wanted to build yet another city and why he chose the specific location. Perhaps it was just to satisfy his ego. Ibn Batuta tells an interesting story that may or may not be